First Round Interview Questions

Resume, HR and behavioral questions with simple sample answers
For AI / ML / Software Engineer interviews

How to use this: Almost every company starts with a first round where they read your resume and ask about you, your projects, why this company, your salary, and your notice period. This PDF has the common questions. Each one has a short explanation and a sample answer in the 'Say in interview' box. **Replace the words in [brackets] with your own real details.** Practice out loud until it sounds natural, but do not memorize it word by word. Always tell the truth in your answers.

Part 1: About You and Your Resume

Q1. Tell me about yourself.

Answer:

This is almost always the first question. Keep it to 1 to 1.5 minutes. Use this simple order: Present (what you do now), Past (what you did before), Future (what you want next and why this company). Do not tell your life story or your family details.

Say in interview: Hello, my name is [Name]. I have [2] years of experience as a [Software / AI engineer]. Currently I work at [Company], where I work on [what you build, for example a RAG chatbot or a data pipeline] using [Python, SQL, LLMs]. In my last project, I [built something] which helped [result, for example reduced manual work by 30 percent]. Before that, I worked on [one line]. Now I want to work on [GenAI systems at a bigger scale], and that is why I am excited about this role at [Company].

Q2. Walk me through your resume.

Answer:

The interviewer wants to see if you can explain your own career clearly. Go in time order, from your education to your current job. For each job, say what you did and what you achieved, not only the tools. Spend most of the time on the latest and most related experience. Know every line of your resume, because they can ask about anything written there.

- Only keep skills on the resume that you can explain.
- Be ready to explain every project and every tool listed.
- Keep numbers ready: data size, users, accuracy, time saved.

Say in interview: I completed my [B.E. / B.Tech] in [branch] from [college] in [year]. Then I joined [Company] as [role]. In the first year I worked on [work], and I learned [skills]. Then I moved to [project], where I was responsible for [your part]. The result was [result]. My strongest skills are [Python, SQL, and ...], and I have also worked on [LLM or ML work].

Q3. Tell me about your current (or latest) project.

Answer:

This is the most important question in the first round, so prepare it well. Explain it in this order: the problem, your role, the tools you used, the hard part, and the result.

- **Problem:** what was the business need?
- **Your role:** what exactly did YOU do (use 'I', not only 'we').

- **Tools:** the tech and the reason you chose it.
- **Challenge:** one hard thing and how you solved it.
- **Result:** a number if possible, like accuracy, time, cost, users.

Say in interview: The project was [name]. The problem was [for example, support teams spent a lot of time searching documents]. I was responsible for [building the retrieval part / the API / the data pipeline]. We used [Python, a vector database, an LLM] because [reason]. The hard part was [for example, answers were sometimes wrong], and I fixed it by [improving chunking and adding a re-ranker]. As a result, [accuracy improved from X to Y / the time was reduced by Z].

Q4. What exactly was your role? What did you do personally, not the team?

Answer:

Interviewers ask this because many people say 'we did this' and take the credit of the whole team. Be clear and honest about your own part. It is fine to say that the team worked together, but then say what your part was.

Say in interview: It was a team of [4]. My part was [the data cleaning and the retrieval module]. I wrote [the code for X], tested it, and fixed [problem]. Another teammate handled [Y]. I also worked with [him or her] to connect the two parts.

Q5. What was the biggest challenge in your project? How did you solve it?

Answer:

Pick a real technical challenge, not a small one. Explain what went wrong, what you tried, what finally worked, and what you learned. Showing how you think matters more than the problem itself.

Say in interview: The biggest challenge was [for example, the model gave wrong answers on some documents]. First I checked [the data and the logs] and found that [the cause]. I tried [first idea], but it did not fully work. Then I tried [second idea], and that fixed it. After that [the result]. I learned to [check the data first before changing the model].

Q6. Which technologies are you strongest in? How do you rate yourself?

Answer:

Be honest. If you say '9 out of 10 in Python', they will ask very hard questions. A safe way is to say your level and give proof from your work. Say what you use daily, and what you know less.

Say in interview: I am strongest in Python and SQL, because I use them daily at work. For example, I [wrote the data pipeline / the queries for X]. I would say I am comfortable at a working level in [RAG and LLM APIs], since I built [project]. I am still learning [Docker / cloud / system design], and I am practicing it now.

Q7. What is your biggest achievement? Which project are you most proud of?

Answer:

Choose something with a clear result and your own contribution. It does not need to be a big thing. A small improvement with a number is a good answer.

Say in interview: I am most proud of [what]. At that time [the problem]. I [what you did], and the result was [number, for example reduced the run time from 2 hours to 20 minutes]. I am proud of it because [it helped the team or the customer].

Q8. There is a gap in your resume, or you changed jobs quickly. Why?

Answer:

Be calm and honest, and keep it short. Give the real reason in a positive way, say what you did in that time (learning, courses, projects, family reasons), and then move the talk to the present. Do not lie, because they can check.

Say in interview: Yes, I had a gap of [months] because of [real reason, for example, a family reason / preparing for a career change]. During that time I [learned X / completed a course / built a project]. I am now fully ready and focused on my career.

Part 2: Why This Job and Why This Company

Q9. Why do you want to leave your current job?

Answer:

Never speak badly about your current company, your manager, or your salary alone. Give positive reasons: you want to learn more, work on bigger scale, or move toward the field you like. Be honest, but keep it positive.

Say in interview: I have learned a lot at [Company], and I am thankful for it. But now I want to [work on larger and more challenging problems, especially in GenAI]. In my current role, [there are limited chances for that]. So I am looking for a place where I can grow in that direction, and this role fits it.

Q10. Why do you want to join this company?

Answer:

This is the question where most people give a weak answer. Do your homework before the interview. Read the company website, its products, its engineering blog, and recent news. Then give 2 or 3 real reasons that connect the company to your skills and interests. Do not say only 'it is a big brand'.

- **Walmart:** a very large retail company with huge data. Think about supply chain, search, pricing, and customer support at scale.
- **Flipkart:** a large Indian e-commerce company (part of Walmart). Think about recommendations, search, fraud, and delivery for millions of customers.
- **Google:** strong in AI research and large-scale systems. Think about the quality of engineering and the AI products.
- **Meta:** a leader in social products and open AI models. Think about the scale of data and the AI work.
- Check the latest facts on the company's own website and news before you say them. These points are only ideas to start your research.

Say in interview: I have three reasons. First, [Company] works on [a real product or problem], and that matches my experience in [your skill]. Second, the scale is very large, with [millions of users], and I want to learn how to build AI systems at that scale. Third, I read about [something specific, like a product or a blog], and it interested me because [reason].

Q11. What do you know about our company?

Answer:

Prepare 4 or 5 facts: what the company does, its main products, its scale, any recent news or launches, and how AI or data is used there. Then connect one fact to your own interest. If you are not sure about a fact, do not say it.

Say in interview: I know that [Company] is [what it does]. Its main products are [products]. Recently I read that [recent news or launch]. I find it interesting because [connect to your work, for example, they use AI for search or support].

Q12. Why do you want this role? Why AI or Machine Learning?

Answer:

Give a real story. What made you start, what you enjoy, and what you have already done. Interest that is backed by real projects sounds much stronger than words.

Say in interview: I enjoy AI because [real reason, for example, it solves problems that normal code cannot]. I started with [course or project], and then built [what]. I like that this role involves [what the job description says], which is exactly what I want to do more of.

Q13. Where do you see yourself in 5 years?

Answer:

They want to know that you have a direction, and that you will grow with them. Do not say 'in your chair' or 'I have no plan'. Talk about growing your skills and your responsibility, and keep it related to the role.

Say in interview: In 5 years, I want to be a strong engineer who can design and build AI systems from start to end, and maybe lead a small team. For that, I want to keep learning, take more ownership, and work on bigger problems. I hope to do this here at [Company].

Q14. What are you looking for in your next job?

Answer:

Give 2 or 3 things: learning, scale, good team, ownership. All of them should match what this company offers.

Say in interview: I am looking for three things: a chance to work on real AI products at scale, a team where I can learn from good engineers, and more ownership of my work. From what I know, this role offers that.

Q15. Why should we hire you?

Answer:

This is your short sales pitch. Say 3 points: your skills that match the job, your proof (a project or result), and your attitude (you learn fast and you take responsibility). Read the job description and match its main needs.

Say in interview: From the job description, you need someone with [Python, SQL, and LLM or RAG experience]. I have [2] years of experience with these, and I have built [project] with [result]. I also learn new things quickly, for example, [one example]. I believe I can start contributing quickly and keep growing with the team.

Part 3: Salary, Notice Period and Logistics

Q16. What is your current CTC?

Answer:

Answer clearly and honestly. Many companies check it later with salary slips or in the background verification, so a wrong number can cancel the offer. Know the exact split: fixed salary, variable or bonus, and any other benefits like stocks. If you want, you can say your fixed and your total separately.

Say in interview: My current fixed salary is [X] lakhs per year. With the variable pay and benefits, my total is around [Y] lakhs per year.

Q17. What is your expected CTC?

Answer:

This is the question people fear most. Prepare before the call:

- **Research the market:** check salary data for the same role, city, and experience on sites like Glassdoor, AmbitionBox, and Levels.fyi. Treat them as a rough guide only, because the numbers vary.
- **Think in total compensation:** fixed salary, variable, joining bonus, stocks, and benefits. Compare the full package, not only one number.
- **Give a range or ask for their range:** a range is safer than a single number. You can ask politely what budget they have for the role.
- **Stay flexible but know your minimum:** decide your lowest acceptable number before the call.
- **Do not lie** about your current salary to get a higher offer.

Say in interview: I have done some research on the market for this role, and based on my skills and the responsibilities, I am looking for something in the range of [X to Y] lakhs. But I am flexible, and for me the role, the learning, and the team are also important. Could you please share the budget range for this position?

Q18. Are you flexible about the salary? Can you negotiate?

Answer:

Show that you are reasonable, but do not undervalue yourself. Negotiation usually happens after the interviews, when they make an offer. At that time, you can ask politely for a higher fixed pay, a joining bonus, or stocks. Stay polite, give reasons, and do not threaten.

Say in interview: Yes, I am open to discussion. I am looking for a good role first, and I am sure we can reach a number that works for both sides. I would like to understand the full package once the offer is ready.

Q19. What is your notice period? Can it be reduced?

Answer:

Tell your exact notice period as per your offer letter. Many companies in India have 30, 60, or 90 days. Check with your HR whether early release or a buyout is possible, because policies are different. Do not promise something you are not sure about.

Say in interview: My notice period is [60] days as per my contract. I will check with my HR if it can be shortened, and I can let you know. I will do my best to join as early as possible.

Q20. When can you join?

Answer:

Count from your notice period. If you have not resigned yet, the joining date is counted after you give the resignation. Be honest and give a realistic date.

Say in interview: I have to serve a notice period of [60] days, so I can join about [2 months] after I get the offer and resign. If I can reduce it, I will tell you immediately.

Q21. Are you willing to relocate, work from office, or work in shifts?

Answer:

Answer honestly, based on the job description. If you have a condition, say it politely at the start, and not after you get the offer. Ask about the work-from-office policy so you know it beforehand.

Say in interview: Yes, I am open to [working from the office in Bangalore / hybrid mode]. I would like to understand the details of the work policy for this team.

Q22. Do you have any other offers or interviews going on?

Answer:

Be honest, but do not give too many details. It is fine to say you are interviewing with other companies. You do not need to name them or the salary. It also shows that you are in demand, but do not use it as a threat.

Say in interview: Yes, I am in the interview process with a few other companies, but this role is one of my top choices because of [reason]. I am happy to share an update when needed.

Part 4: Behavioral Questions (STAR Method)

Q23. What is the STAR method?

Answer:

Behavioral questions start with 'Tell me about a time when...'. They want a real story from your past. The STAR method keeps the story clear and short.

- **S - Situation:** the background in one or two sentences.
- **T - Task:** what you had to do or what the problem was.
- **A - Action:** what YOU did, step by step. Spend most of the time here.
- **R - Result:** the outcome, with a number if you can, and what you learned.
- Prepare 4 or 5 real stories before the interview (a failure, a conflict, a deadline, a learning, a success). You can change the same story to fit many questions.

Say in interview: I use the STAR method: the situation, the task, my action, and the result. I keep the story short and focus on what I did.

Q24. Tell me about a time you failed or made a mistake.

Answer:

Do not say 'I never failed'. Choose a real but not very serious mistake. Show that you took responsibility (not blaming others), fixed it, and learned something that you use now.

Say in interview: In [project], I [made a mistake, for example, I pushed a change without testing on the full data], and it caused [problem]. I told my team right away, and then I [fixed it in X hours]. After

that, I started [adding tests and checking on a sample before every release]. Since then, I have not had that problem.

Q25. Tell me about a conflict or disagreement with a teammate or manager.

Answer:

Choose a small and professional disagreement, not a personal fight. Show that you listened, used data or facts, stayed respectful, and reached a solution. Never blame the other person.

Say in interview: In [project], my teammate and I disagreed about [for example, which approach to use]. I listened to his or her reasons, and then I suggested we test both on a small sample and compare the results. The data showed that [outcome], and we went with it. We are still working well together.

Q26. Tell me about a time you worked under a tight deadline or pressure.

Answer:

Show that you can plan, prioritize, and communicate. Say what you did first, what you postponed, and how you informed others.

Say in interview: Once, we had [3 days] to deliver [what]. I broke the work into small parts, finished the most important part first, and told my manager early about what could be delayed. I also asked [a teammate] for help on [part]. We delivered the main feature on time, and finished the rest the next week.

Q27. Tell me about a time you learned a new technology quickly.

Answer:

This is a favorite question for AI roles, because the field changes fast. Show how you learn: documentation, a small project, asking others, and then using it in real work.

Say in interview: When my project needed [RAG / a new tool], I did not know it. I read the official documentation, followed a tutorial, and built a small prototype in [2 days]. Then I used it in the real project, and asked a senior for a review. In [2 weeks] I was using it in production.

Q28. Tell me about a time you disagreed with a decision, or took ownership beyond your role.

Answer:

Show that you can speak up politely with facts, and that you care about the result and not only your own tasks. Describe a time you saw a problem and fixed it without being asked, or raised a concern in the right way.

Say in interview: In [project], I noticed that [problem, for example, the data had many duplicates and it affected the results]. It was not my task, but I checked it, showed the numbers to my manager, and offered to fix it. We fixed it, and the model accuracy improved by [X].

Q29. How do you handle feedback and criticism?

Answer:

Show that you listen without getting defensive, and that you act on it. Give a real example of feedback that helped you.

Say in interview: I take feedback as a chance to improve. Once, my reviewer told me that [for example, my code was hard to read]. I asked for examples, then worked on it, and now I [write smaller functions and add comments]. I also ask for feedback regularly.

Q30. How do you explain a technical idea to a non-technical person?

Answer:

Show that you can use simple words and examples, and focus on what matters to them: the benefit, the risk, the cost. This skill is very important for AI engineers.

Say in interview: I avoid technical words and use an example from their daily work. For instance, I explain RAG as 'the AI first looks up the right pages in our documents and then writes the answer from them'. I then focus on what they care about: the accuracy, the cost, and the timeline.

Q31. What are your strengths and weaknesses?

Answer:

Strength: pick 2 that match the job, and give a short proof for each. **Weakness:** pick a real one that is not critical for the job, and say what you are doing to improve. Do not say fake weaknesses like 'I work too hard' or 'I am a perfectionist'.

Say in interview: My strengths are that I learn quickly and I take ownership. For example, [proof]. A weakness is that [for example, I sometimes spend too long trying to fix a problem alone before asking for help]. I am working on it by setting a time limit, and then I ask my team.

Q32. How do you stay updated in AI?

Answer:

The field changes every month, so they want to see a learning habit. Give real sources and say what you actually do.

Say in interview: I follow [a few blogs and newsletters / the official docs of the model providers / research papers on arXiv summaries], and I try new tools in small projects on weekends. Recently, I built [small project] to learn [topic].

Q33. What do you do when you are given a task that you do not know how to do?

Answer:

Show a clear and honest way of working. You try first, then you ask, and you do not stay stuck silently.

Say in interview: First I try to understand the problem and search the documentation. I try for a fixed time, like an hour or two. If I am still stuck, I ask a teammate with a clear description of what I tried. I also write down the solution afterward, so others can use it.

Q34. What would you do if an AI model you deployed gave a wrong or harmful answer?

Answer:

This is a behavioral question for AI roles. It checks ownership and a calm, step-by-step way of handling incidents.

- Tell the team and the stakeholders quickly, and be honest about it.
- Reduce the harm first: turn off the feature or add a temporary filter if needed.
- Find the root cause: check the logs, the retrieved data, the prompt, and the model.

- Fix it, and add that case to the test set so it does not happen again.
- Add monitoring, guardrails, and human review for risky cases.

Say in interview: I would first stop the harm, then inform the team, find the root cause from the logs, fix it, and add that case to my tests and monitoring.

Part 5: Closing the Interview

Q35. Do you have any questions for us?

Answer:

Always say yes. Having no questions looks like low interest. Ask 2 or 3 good questions about the work and the team. Do not ask about salary, leave, or holidays in the first round, unless they bring it up.

- What kind of problems will this team work on in the first 6 months?
- What does a good first 90 days look like for this role?
- How is the team organized, and who would I work with daily?
- What tools and tech stack does the team use for LLM and ML work?
- How do you measure success for this role?
- What are the next steps in the interview process?

Say in interview: Yes, I have two questions. What kind of problems will the team work on in the first six months, and what does success look like for this role?

Q36. Quick tips for the first round

Answer:

A few simple habits make a big difference:

- Read the job description again before the call. Match your answers to it.
- Know your resume 100 percent. Every skill listed can be asked.
- Prepare the 4 big answers: yourself, your project, why this company, and your salary details.
- Speak slowly and clearly. Short answers (1 to 2 minutes) are better than long stories.
- Be honest. If you do not know something, say so and say how you would find out.
- Keep the camera, the internet, and a quiet place ready. Keep a pen and paper.
- Say thank you at the end, and send a short thank-you message if you can.

Always tell the truth about your experience, your salary, and your notice period. Your answers should be your own words and your own real stories. Good luck with your interviews!